

RH05

Marwar, Dhundhar, Bikaner, Jaisalmer, Hadoti & Other States

The single largest slice of Rajasthan History - expect 3-5 questions a paper. RAS 2024 alone carried three Marwar questions (Rao Siha, Rao Chunda-Mandore, Rao Jodha-1459) and RAS 2023 asked Jaipur's planner.

This is the biggest chapter in the subject, and the one students turn into an undifferentiated blur of Rajput names. Do not read it as one list. Read it house by house. Each house has a founder, a fort, one or two rulers who mattered to the Mughals or the British, and a builder or two - and RPSC asks exactly those four slots.

The princely houses of Rajputana

Marwar (Rathore)

- Rao Siha
- Rao Jodha - Mehrangarh 1459
- Rao Maldeo - Gori Sumel
- Chandrasen
- Jaswant Singh, Durgadas

Hadoti (Hada Chauhan)

- Bundi - Rao Deva 1241
- Rao Surjan - Ranthambore 1569
- Kota split 1631
- Zalim Singh Jhala
- Gagron jal-durg

Dhundhar (Kachhwaha)

- Dulha Rai, Kokil Dev
- Bharmal - Akbar
- Man Singh I
- Mirza Raja Jai Singh I
- Sawai Jai Singh II - Jaipur 1727

Jat and eastern states

- Bharatpur - Suraj Mal, Lohagarh
- Alwar - Pratap Singh Naruka 1775
- Dholpur - Bamrolia Jat
- Karauli - Jadaun
- Tonk - Amir Khan 1817

Desert houses

- Bikaner - Rao Bika 1488
- Rai Singh - Junagarh
- Ganga Singh - Gang Canal
- Jaisalmer - Rawal Jaisal
- Three sakas of Jaisalmer

Southern and smaller houses

- Sirohi - Deora Chauhan
- Dungarpur, Banswara, Pratapgarh - Guhil (Vagad)
- Kishangarh - Bani Thani
- Shekhawati - Rao Shekha

The map of houses - read this before any ruler's name

Before you memorise a single ruler, fix which clan sits where. Half the questions in this chapter are clan-to-state or founder-to-state matching, and if the clan map is clear the matching answers itself. Note the pattern: Rathores in the west, Kachhwahas in the east, Hada Chauhans in the south-east, and Jats and a Pathan house on the Agra side.

Clan to state to seat - the spine of the chapter

House / clan	State	Capital or chief fort
Rathore	Marwar	Mandore, then Jodhpur - Mehrangarh
Rathore (Bika branch)	Bikaner	Bikaner - Junagarh
Kachhwaha	Dhundhar	Amber, then Jaipur
Kachhwaha (Naruka branch)	Alwar	Bala Qila
Bhati	Jaisalmer	Lodrava, then Jaisalmer - Sonar Qila
Hada Chauhan	Bundi and Kota (Hadoti)	Taragarh, Bundi
Deora Chauhan	Sirohi	Sirohi
Guhil (Vagad branch)	Dungarpur, Banswara, Pratapgarh	Dungarpur
Jadaun / Yaduvanshi	Karauli	Karauli
Sinsinwar Jat	Bharatpur	Lohagarh
Bamrolia Jat	Dholpur	Dholpur
Pathan (Amir Khan's line)	Tonk	Tonk

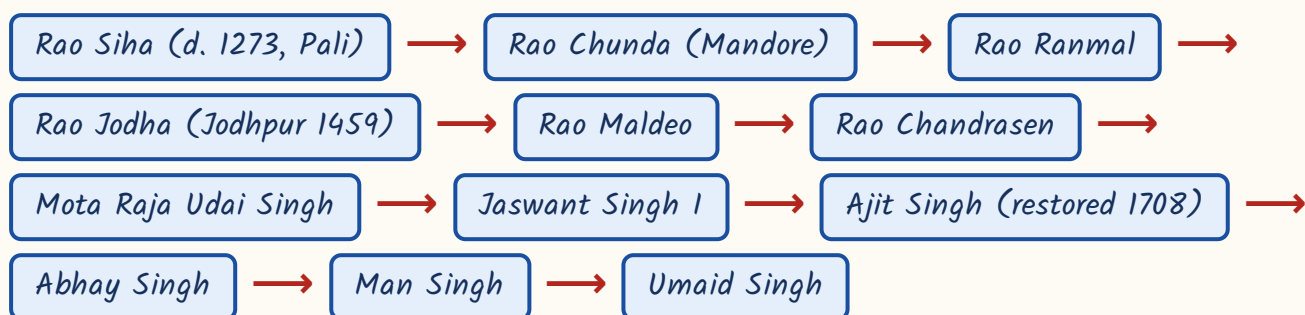
- Kota is Hada Chauhan, not Rathore - this exact swap is used as a wrong pair.

- Karauli is Yaduvanshi (Jadaun); Sirohi is Deora Chauhan; Tonk is the only Muslim princely state of Rajputana.
- Bikaner and Kishangarh are both Rathore offshoots of Jodhpur - founded by sons of Jodhpur rulers.

Marwar - the Rathores of Jodhpur

Marwar is the largest of the states and the one that fought the Mughals longest at the level of ordinary politics. Its story has a clear shape: found a base at Pali, capture Mandore, build Jodhpur, lose to Sher Shah, resist Akbar, then submit, then rebel again under Aurangzeb, and finally be restored in 1708. Hold that arc and the names slot in.

Rathore ruler chain - Marwar



- Rao Siha (d. 1273), around Pali, is the founder of the Rathores of Marwar.
- Rao Chunda obtained MANDORE and made it his capital.
- Rao Ranmal was killed at Chittor in 1438 - the Mewar connection turning sour.
- Rao Jodha founded JODHPUR and laid Mehrangarh's foundation on Chidiyatunk hill, 12 May 1459.
- Mehrangarh's other names: Garh Chintamani and Mayurdhwaj.
- Rao Maldeo (1532-62) - the 'Hashmat Wala Raja' of the Persian chroniclers, the strongest Rajput ruler of his day.

- Defeated by Sher Shah Suri at GIRI SUMEL (Sammel), January 1544.
 - His commanders Jaita and Kumpa fell in that battle.
 - Sher Shah's famous line after it: 'for a handful of bajra I nearly lost the empire of Hindustan'.
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- Rao Chandrasen (1562-81) - the 'Pratap of Marwar', also called the forgotten hero.
 - He walked out of Akbar's NAGAUR darbar (1570) rather than submit.
 - Carried on the fight from BHADRAJUN and SIWANA.
 - Mota Raja Udai Singh (1583-95) was the first Rathore of Marwar to accept Mughal suzerainty.
 - His daughter Jagat Gosain (Jodhabai) married Prince Salim and was the mother of Shah Jahan.
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- Amar Singh Rathore of Nagaur - 'Katar ka Dhani'; fought the Battle of Matira ri Rad (the Battle of the Watermelon, 1644) against Bikaner.
 - Maharaja Jaswant Singh I (1638-78) fought Aurangzeb at DHARMAT (1658) on Dara Shikoh's side.
 - Jaswant Singh died at Jamrud in 1678 - and his death triggered the Rajput war.
 - His court held MUHNOT NAINSI, author of 'Nainsi ri Khyat' and 'Marwar ra Pargana ri Vigat'.
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- DURGADAS RATHORE - the 'Redeemer of Marwar'; he shielded the infant Ajit Singh for thirty years against Aurangzeb.
 - Durgadas's chhatri stands at Ujjain, on the Shipra.
 - Ajit Singh was finally recognised as ruler of Marwar in 1708.
 - Khejarli sacrifice, 1730, in Abhay Singh's reign - Amrita Devi Bishnoi and 363 people died protecting khejri trees.
 - The Amrita Devi Bishnoi Wildlife Protection Award is named after her.

- Maharaja Man Singh of Jodhpur (1803-43) patronised the NATH sect and built the Mahamandir.
- The Battle of Gingoli (1807) grew out of the Krishna Kumari dispute.
- Maharaja Umaid Singh built UMAID BHAWAN palace, begun 1929.

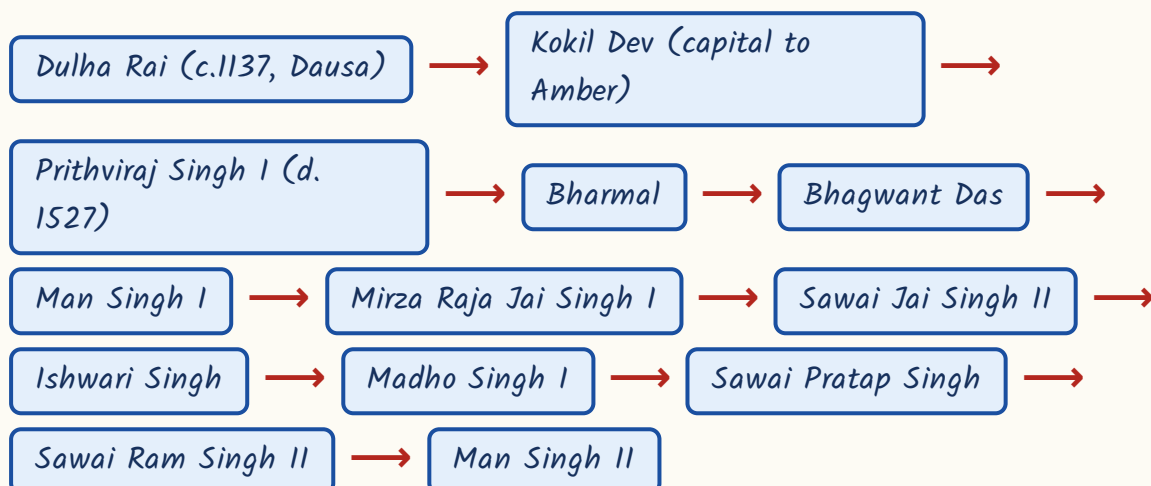
ASKED IN RAS

RAS Pre 2024 mined Marwar three times over - the founder of the Rathore dynasty (Rao Siha), who obtained Mandore and made it the capital (Rao Chunda), and who founded Jodhpur and Mehrangarh in 1459 (Rao Jodha). The same paper ran the negative version: 'which statement about Rao Jodha is NOT correct' - the false one being that he founded Bikaner. Bikaner was his son Bika.

Dhundhar - the Kachhwahas of Amber and Jaipur

Dhundhar took the opposite road from Marwar. Where Marwar resisted and paid for it, Amber allied early and rose inside the Mughal system - the highest Rajput mansab, the governorship of Bengal, the negotiator who brought Shivaji to terms. Then in the eighteenth century it turned scientific and built a planned city. Two very different kinds of fame, both examinable.

Kachhwaha ruler chain - Amber to Jaipur



- Dulha Rai (c. 1137), based at Dausa, founded the Kachhwaha state of Dhundhar.
 - Kokil Dev shifted the capital to AMBER.
 - Prithviraj Singh I (reigned to 1527) fought beside Rana Sanga at Khanwa.
 - The estates settled on Prithviraj's sons and kinsmen became the 'Barah Kotri' - the twelve great chieftainships of the house.
 - Raja Bharmal was the first Rajput ruler to ally with Akbar; his daughter Harkha Bai married Akbar in 1562 at Sambhar.
 - Bharmal's son Bhagwant Das carried the alliance forward into the next generation.
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- Raja MAN SINGH I held the highest mansab of 7,000 under Akbar.
 - Governor of Kabul, Bihar and Bengal; commanded the Mughal army at Haldighati, 1576.
 - Built the Amber palace and the Govind Dev temple at Vrindavan.
 - Brought the SHILA DEVI idol from Bengal and installed it at Amber.
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- MIRZA RAJA JAI SINGH I signed the TREATY OF PURANDAR with Shivaji on 11 June 1665.
 - Under it Shivaji surrendered 23 of his 35 forts.
 - His court poet was Bihari, author of the 'Bihari Satsai'.
 - He died at Burhanpur in 1667.
-
- SAWAI JAI SINGH II (1700-43) received the title 'Sawai' from Aurangzeb.
 - Founded JAIPUR on 18 November 1727, to the plan of VIDYADHAR BHATTACHARYA.
 - Built five Jantar Mantars - Jaipur, Delhi, Ujjain, Mathura, Varanasi.
 - Compiled the astronomical tables 'Zij-i-Muhammad Shahi'; also built Nahargarh.
 - Jaipur became a UNESCO World Heritage City in 2019.

- Sawai Ishwari Singh won the Battle of Rajmahal (1747) and built the ISAR LAT (Sargasuli); he lost Bagru in 1748 and died in 1750.
- Madho Singh I founded Sawai Madhopur in 1763.
- Sawai Pratap Singh built HAWA MAHAL (1799) - architect Lal Chand Ustad, 953 jharokhas.
- Pratap Singh wrote poetry under the pen-name 'Brajnidhi' and fought the Marathas at Tunga (1787).
- Sawai Ram Singh II (1835-80) had Jaipur painted pink in 1876 to welcome the Prince of Wales.
- He built Albert Hall and the Ram Prakash Theatre, founded Maharaja College and Rajasthan's first girls' school.
- Man Singh II was the last ruler of Jaipur and the first Rajpramukh of Rajasthan.

Marwar vs Amber - two answers to the same Mughal question

Marwar (Rathore)	Amber (Kachhwaha)
Maldeo defied the Mughals' predecessors and fell at Giri Sumel (1544)	Bharmal allied with Akbar in 1562 - the first Rajput chief to do so
Chandrasen walked out of the Nagaur darbar (1570)	Man Singh I rose to a mansab of 7,000 and governed Bengal
Submitted only under Mota Raja Udai Singh (1583)	Supplied the Mughals' commander at Haldighati (1576)
Rebelled again in 1679-81; restored only in 1708	Negotiated for the Mughals at Purandar (1665)

ASKED IN RAS

Asked in RAS Pre 2023 - who prepared the plan of Jaipur, founded in 1727?

Answer: Vidyadhar Bhattacharya. Note the pairing RPSC likes: Jai Singh II founds, Vidyadhar plans, Lal Chand Ustad builds the Hawa Mahal for Pratap Singh.

CURRENT LINK

Current link (as of March 2026): the Walled City of Jaipur, inscribed by UNESCO in 2019, is under scrutiny over construction inside its core and buffer zones; the state has to file a conservation report by December 2026 or risk a reactive monitoring mission and the 'World Heritage in Danger' list. Heritage havelis in the walled city have fallen from about 1,200 in 1991 to roughly 800.

Bikaner - the desert Rathores

Bikaner is a Jodhpur offshoot. Rao Bika, a son of Rao Jodha, went north into the Jangal country and founded his own state. The house then supplies two very examinable figures - Rai Singh the fort-builder and Ganga Singh the moderniser.

- Rao Bika, son of Rao Jodha, founded BIKANER in 1488, on Akshaya Tritiya.
- He also built the Karni Mata temple at Deshnok.
- Rai Singh (1574-1612), a general of Akbar, built JUNAGARH fort (1589-94).
- Karan Singh received the title 'Jangaldhar Badshah'.
- Anup Singh founded the ANUP SANSKRIT LIBRARY.
- Surat Singh captured Bhatner in 1805 and renamed it Hanumangarh.

- Maharaja GANGA SINGH (1887-1943) is called the 'Bhagirath of Rajasthan'.
- He brought the GANG CANAL, opened in 1927 - Rajasthan's oldest canal system.
- Raised the Ganga Risala camel corps; sat in the Imperial War Cabinet.
- Signed the Treaty of Versailles for India in 1919 and was the first Chancellor of the Chamber of Princes.

TRAP

Ganga Singh was NOT the first Rajpramukh of Rajasthan - that was Man Singh II of Jaipur, and the first Rajpramukh of the earlier United State of Rajasthan was Bhupal Singh of Mewar. This is the standard 'NOT correct' option on Ganga Singh.

Jaisalmer - the Bhatias and their three sakas

Jaisalmer is short and high-yield. One founder, one capital shift, three sakas. Learn the third one carefully - it is called the 'ardh saka', a half saka, because the jauhar could not be completed.

- Rawal Jaisal shifted the capital from LODRAVA and founded Jaisalmer.
- First saka - under Mulraj and Ratan Singh, against Alauddin Khilji.
- Second saka - against Firoz Shah Tughlaq.
- Third saka, the 'ardh saka' (c. 1550), under Rawal Lunkaran - the jauhar could not be completed.
- Jaisalmer's fort, the Sonar Qila, is one of the UNESCO Hill Forts of Rajasthan.

ASKED IN RAS

Asked in RAS Pre 2023 as a two-statement question on Jaisalmer - that Rawal Jaisal shifted the capital from Lodrava, and that the third saka was the incomplete 'ardh saka'. Both true. Statement-based questions are about 19% of the paper now, so expect this format on the smaller states.

Hadoti - Bundi, Kota and Jhalawar

Hadoti is the south-eastern corner - the Hada branch of the Chauhans. One state becomes three: Bundi first, Kota carved out of it by Shah Jahan, and Jhalawar carved out of Kota by the British. That sequence of splits is itself a question.

- Rao Deva founded BUNDI in 1241 after defeating the Meena chief Jaita.
 - Rao Surjan Singh surrendered RANTHAMBORE to Akbar in 1569 and received the title 'Rao Raja'.
 - Rao Ratan Singh received the title 'Sarbuland Rai' from Jahangir.
 - Rao Chhatrasal built the Chhatra Mahal and fell at Samugarh (1658).
 - Rao Umed Singh built the Chitrashala - the painting gallery of Bundi.
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- KOTA was separated from Bundi in 1631 by Shah Jahan, for Rao Madho Singh.
 - Zalim Singh Jhala, Kota's great administrator, won the Battle of BHATWARA (1761) against Jaipur.
 - JHALAWAR was carved out of Kota in 1838 for Jhala Madan Singh.
 - Jhalawar was the last princely state created in Rajputana.
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- GAGRON fort (Jhalawar) sits at the confluence of the Ahu and the Kali Sindh.
 - It is the classic JAL-DURG - the water fort - of Rajasthan, and a UNESCO Hill Fort.
 - Achaldas Khichi died defending Gagrion against Hoshang Shah of Malwa.

The Jat and eastern states - Bharatpur, Alwar, Dholpur, Karauli,

Tonk

These are the eighteenth and nineteenth century states on the Agra-Delhi side, and none of them is Rajput-Rathore. Two are Jat, one is a Kachhwaha offshoot, one Yaduvanshi, one Pathan. Each needs exactly one founder and one anchor fact.

- BHARATPUR is a Jat state of the Sinsinwar clan; Churaman and Badan Singh laid its foundations.
- Maharaja SURAJ MAL (d. 25 December 1763) is called the 'Plato of the Jat community'.
- Suraj Mal built LOHAGARH fort and the Deeg palaces.
- ALWAR was founded on 25 December 1775 by Rao Raja Pratap Singh Naruka - the Narukas are a Kachhwaha offshoot.
- Alwar's fort is the Bala Qila; Bakhtawar Singh signed with Wellesley in 1803 after the Battle of Laswari.
- DHOLPUR went to the Jat Rana Kirat Singh of Gohad in 1805-06 - a Bamrolia Jat house.
- KARALI is Yaduvanshi (Jadaun); Arjun Pal established its capital in 1348.
- TONK, founded in 1817 by the Pindari leader Amir Khan, was the ONLY Muslim princely state of Rajputana.

The southern and smaller houses

Finish the chapter with the houses that appear once every few papers. You need clan, founder and one hook for each - no more. Note the Vagad group in the south: Dungarpur, Banswara and Pratapgarh are all Guhil, cousins of Mewar.

- SIROHI is Deora Chauhan; Rao Sahastramal founded Sirohi city in 1425, his father Rao Sobha having founded Shivpuri in 1405.

- Sirohi was the LAST Rajputana state to sign a treaty with the British, in 1823.
- Karauli, by contrast, was the first to sign (1817) - remember the pair as first and last.
- DUNGARPUR, BANSWARA and PRATAPGARH belong to the Guhil (Vagad) branch - the Mewar family's southern cousins.
- Banswara separated from Dungarpur; Pratapgarh is also called Deolia-Pratapgarh.
- KISHANGARH was founded by Kishan Singh, a son of Mota Raja Udai Singh of Jodhpur.
- Kishangarh produced Savant Singh (the poet Nagari Das) and the Bani Thani painting.
- SHEKHAWATI is named after Rao Shekha (1433-88), a Kachhwaha of Amarsar.

One-page revision - founders, battles, epithets

Founder to state - the commonest matching set

Founder	State / city	Year
Rao Siha	Rathores of Marwar (Pali region)	d. 1273
Rao Deva	Bundi	1241
Rao Jodha	Jodhpur and Mehrangarh	1459
Rao Bika	Bikaner	1488
Rao Madho Singh	Kota (split from Bundi)	1631
Sawai Jai Singh II	Jaipur	1727
Madho Singh I	Sawai Madhopur	1763
Pratap Singh Naruka	Alwar	1775
Amir Khan	Tonk	1817

Founder	State / city	Year
Jhala Madan Singh	Jhalawar (split from Kota)	1838

Battles of the other states – and who fought whom

Battle and year	Sides	Outcome
Giri Sumel, 1544	Rao Maldeo vs Sher Shah Suri	Marwar defeated; Jaita and Kumpa killed
Matira ri Rad, 1644	Amar Singh Rathore of Nagaur vs Bikaner	The 'Battle of the Watermelon'
Dharmat, 1658	Jaswant Singh I (for Dara) vs Aurangzeb	Jaswant Singh defeated
Samugarh, 1658	Rao Chhatrasal of Bundi killed	Mughal succession war
Bhatwara, 1761	Kota under Zalim Singh Jhala vs Jaipur	Kota wins
Rajmahal, 1747 / Bagru, 1748	Ishwari Singh of Jaipur	Won Rajmahal, lost Bagru
Tunga, 1787	Sawai Pratap Singh vs the Marathas	Jaipur holds
Gingoli, 1807	Jodhpur vs Jaipur, over Krishna Kumari	Marwar-Dhundhar rupture
Laswari, 1803	Marathas vs the British	Alwar signs with Wellesley after it

YAAD RAKHO

Epithet drill – Maldeo is 'Hashmat Wala Raja', Chandrasen is the 'Pratap of Marwar', Durgadas is the 'Redeemer of Marwar', Suraj Mal is the 'Plato of the Jats', Ganga Singh is the 'Bhagirath of Rajasthan', Karan Singh of Bikaner is 'Jangaldhar Badshah'. RPSC asks these as a match-the-following almost verbatim.

TRAP

Two Jai Singhs, two Amar Singhs, two Man Singhs. Mirza Raja Jai Singh I (Purandar, 1665) is not Sawai Jai Singh II (Jaipur, 1727). Amar Singh Rathore of Nagaur (Katar ka Dhani) is not Amar Singh I of Mewar (treaty of 1615). Man Singh I of Amber (Haldighati) is not Maharaja Man Singh of Jodhpur (Nath sect, Mahamandir).

REVISION RECAP

1. Marwar: Rao Siha founder, Rao Chunda took Mandore, Rao Jodha built Jodhpur and Mehrangarh on 12 May 1459.
2. Mehrangarh is also Garh Chintamani and Mayurdhwaj; Chidiyatunk is its hill.
3. Maldeo, 'Hashmat Wala Raja', lost Giri Sumel to Sher Shah in January 1544; Jaita and Kumpa died there.
4. Chandrasen resisted from Bhadrachal and Siwana; Mota Raja Udai Singh was the first Rathore to submit, in 1583.
5. Jaswant Singh I fought at Dharmat 1658 and died at Jamrud 1678; Muhnot Nainsi was his minister.
6. Durgadas Rathore protected Ajit Singh for thirty years; Ajit Singh restored 1708; chhatra at Ujjain.
7. Khejarli 1730: Amrita Devi Bishnoi and 363 others; the state wildlife award carries her name.
8. Dhundhar: Dulha Rai founder, Kokil Dev moved to Amber, Prithviraj Singh I's settlement created the Barah Kotri.
9. Bharmal allied with Akbar in 1562 (Sambhar); Man Singh I held mansab 7,000 and brought Shila Devi from Bengal.
10. Mirza Raja Jai Singh I - Purandar 1665, 23 of 35 forts, poet Bihari, died Burhanpur 1667.
11. Sawai Jai Singh II - 'Sawai' from Aurangzeb, Jaipur 1727 planned by Vidyadhar, five Jantar Mantars, Zij-i-Muhammad Shahi.
12. Hawa Mahal 1799 by Sawai Pratap Singh, architect Lal Chand Ustad, 953 jharokhas; Isar Lat by Ishwari Singh.
13. Ram Singh II painted Jaipur pink in 1876 for the Prince of Wales; Man Singh II was the first Rajpramukh of Rajasthan.
14. Bikaner: Rao Bika 1488, Junagarh by Rai Singh, Anup Sanskrit Library by Anup Singh, Bhatner renamed Hanumangarh 1805.

15. Ganga Singh - Gang Canal 1927, Ganga Risala, Versailles 1919, first Chancellor of the Chamber of Princes.
16. Jaisalmer: Rawal Jaisal moved from Lodrava; three sakas, the third an incomplete 'ardh saka' under Lunkaran.
17. Hadoti: Bundi 1241 by Rao Deva; Ranthambore surrendered 1569 by Rao Surjan; Kota split 1631; Jhalawar 1838, the last new state.
18. Gagron at the Ahu-Kali Sindh confluence is the jal-durg; Achaldas Khichi died defending it.
19. Bharatpur - Sinsinwar Jats, Suraj Mal, Lohagarh and Deeg; Alwar - Naruka Kachhwaha, 1775; Tonk - Amir Khan, 1817, the only Muslim state.
20. Sirohi signed last with the British (1823); Kishangarh gave us Nagari Das and the Bani Thani; Shekhawati is named for Rao Shekha.